and 17.41 percent quota at the IMF. Although the U.S. share has declined over time, procedural rules in both institutions require a supermajority (ranging from 70 to 85 percent) for major decisions, including approval of adjustments in quotas, changes to the articles of agreement, and allocation of Special Drawing Rights (SDRs), so as to allow a U.S. veto alone or with a single partner.

In addition to the lags in adjusting voting shares over the past two decades, emerging economies have challenged leadership appointments and the distribution of "chairs" in the so-called "shares and chairs" negotiations. The allocation of chairs, or country representation, through the current 24-member Board of Executive Directors (EDs), which is authorized to supervise IMF activities, has also involved considerations of politics and power.[14] In two important cases, this has worked to the advantage of the BRICS, as China and Russia were given single-constituency seats elected by their own governments when they returned to the Bretton Woods fold (see Chapters 1 and 4).

Under the current rules (revised by the 14th General Review), the process by which countries with the five largest quotas (at present the major Western powers: the United States, Japan, Germany, United Kingdom, and France) are able to appoint a member of the IMF Board is supposed to end. Eventually, all EDs will be elected by more than one country. Also, by the time the quota reform takes effect, the advanced European countries are supposed to lose two of their nine chairs given their reduced position in the world economy.[15] The other seventeen chairs are grouped in unbalanced constituencies under elected EDs, whose fortunes involve some measure of bargaining, while the member-states cannot form cross-constituency coalitions to vote together.[16]

Both shares and chairs are also determined by the formulas of key indicators whose selection (or exclusion) and weighting have long favored Western powers, given their traditional dominance in the international distribution of power. However, the decline of Europe and rise of Asia, as well as the emergence of the BRICS, are some of the factors that have caused distributional conflict over informal rules such as formulas. For example, the current formula allocates 30 percent to "openness," or integration into the world economy. It relies on a peculiar methodology supported by the European Commission, which includes intra-European trade in the tabulation of imports and exports. BRICS and experts from other countries have criticized such practices, which have led to the bizarre result of smaller